

# What Belongs to the Poor

*What the Ancient Church Knew About Wealth and Justice*

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What Belongs to the Poor

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Published by LiveWell by James Bell. [livewellbyjamesbell.co](http://livewellbyjamesbell.co)

Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*The bread you are storing up belongs to the hungry. The  
cloak kept in your closet belongs to the naked. The money  
you have buried belongs to the poor.*

**BASIL OF CAESAREA**

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## INTRODUCTION

# The Bread You Are Hoarding

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**IN THE MIDDLE OF** the fourth century, a bishop in what is now Turkey stood up to preach to his comfortable congregation during a famine, and said a thing so severe that we have spent sixteen hundred years quietly explaining it away. The bread you are storing up, Basil of Caesarea told them, belongs to the hungry. The cloak kept in your closet belongs to the naked. The shoes rotting in your cupboard belong to the man who has none. He was not reaching for a shocking image. He was stating what he took to be plain Christian doctrine, as ordinary and binding as the creed, that the surplus you are sitting on is not yours to give. It already belongs to the poor, and to keep it is not stinginess. It is theft.

Read that with modern ears and everything in you flinches. It sounds like socialism, or like hyperbole, or like the kind of thing a person says when he has gotten carried away. We have a hundred reflexes for defanging it, and we deploy them instantly, because Basil is threatening something we hold very dear. But Basil was not a radical at the edge of the

church. He was one of its great pillars, a defender of orthodoxy, a man whose name is attached to creeds and liturgies still in use, and what he is saying is not his private opinion. It is the common mind of the ancient church, repeated by Ambrose in Milan and Chrysostom in Constantinople and Clement in Alexandria in language just as hard. The early church believed, as a matter of settled doctrine, that what you do not need belongs by right to the one who does, and that giving it to him is not charity. It is justice. It is returning what you were only ever holding.

I want to be honest that this doctrine indicts me before it indicts anyone reading. I have read past these verses my whole Christian life, and past these Fathers entirely, and I have called my own comfort stewardship and my own hoarding prudence, and I have felt generous when I gave away a little of a great deal. The point of this book is not to make you feel guilty, because guilt is cheap and changes nothing. The point is to recover something the church actually believed and then forgot, a teaching so central that for the first centuries it was simply assumed, and so buried now that to state it plainly sounds like a political provocation rather than the orthodox Christianity it is.

Because that is what happened to it. We did not argue our way out of the ancient teaching on wealth and the poor. We did something quieter and more effective. We changed its category. We took what the Fathers called justice, owed and required, and renamed it charity, optional and praiseworthy, a nice thing the especially generous Christian might do, rather than the bare minimum required of anyone who would not be a thief. And then, in our own moment, we finished the job by handing the whole subject over to politics, filing concern for the poor under the platform of one party so that

the other could ignore it with a clear conscience, and treating the most relentless theme in all of Scripture as though it were a partisan talking point a faithful Christian could take or leave.

So I am not going to give you a political program, because the left has made the poor into a program and lost the soul of the thing, and I am not going to give you a guilt trip, because the right has made the poor into an afterthought and lost the command. I am going to try to do something older and harder, which is to put us back under the gaze of the prophets and the Fathers and the Lord they served, and to recover what the church knew in its bones before it grew rich and respectable and forgot. The poor are not a cause. They are the place God has always said he could be found, and what we do with the bread in our cupboards is, it turns out, what we are doing with him.

## CHAPTER ONE

# What Belongs to the Poor

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**LET US STAY WITH** the hard doctrine long enough to feel its full weight, because everything else depends on it, and because the modern church has never really heard it. The claim of the Fathers was not merely that the rich ought to be generous to the poor. That much we can absorb without flinching, because it leaves the rich man in charge, dispensing his surplus as a benefactor, praised for his kindness, the poor man grateful and beneath him. The claim of the Fathers was something far more dangerous. It was that the surplus did not belong to the rich man in the first place, that in keeping it he was holding stolen property, and that to give it to the poor was not to bestow a gift but to discharge a debt.

Hear them say it in their own words, because no paraphrase carries the force. Ambrose of Milan, the bishop who baptized Augustine, wrote this without any sense that he was being extreme. You are not making a gift of your possessions to the poor person. You are handing over to him

what is his. For what was given to everyone for the use of all, you have taken for yourself. The earth belongs to all, not to the rich. John Chrysostom, the greatest preacher of the ancient church, whose very name means golden-mouthed, put it more sharply still. Not to share our own wealth with the poor is theft from the poor and deprivation of their means of life. We do not possess our own wealth but theirs. This is not the language of charity. It is the language of a courtroom, of property law, of restitution. The Fathers looked at the man with a full barn and a neighbor with an empty stomach and did not see a generous donor and a grateful recipient. They saw a thief and his victim.

The logic underneath it is older and deeper than any economic theory, and it is simply this. God made the earth and its goods for all his children, in common, as a father provides for a whole household, and the divisions of property that let one man accumulate while another starves are a human arrangement, useful within limits, but never absolute and never able to override the original purpose, which was that all should be fed. So when you hold a surplus while your neighbor lacks necessities, you have not committed a crime against the state, you have committed a crime against the order of creation, you have diverted to yourself what God sent for someone else. Basil asked his congregation a question that has never stopped stinging. When someone strips a man of his clothes we call him a thief. The one who might clothe the naked and does not, should he not be given the same name?

I can feel, writing this, every objection rising, and they are the right objections to raise, because the Fathers were not fools and they were not communists and the point is not that property is evil or that the answer is a government program.

The point, for now, is narrower and more personal and harder to escape. It is that the modern Christian has been allowed to believe that his accumulation is morally neutral, that what he does not give away is simply, unquestionably his, and that any sharing he does is a credit to his character. And the ancient church, with one voice, said no. It said the question is not whether you were generous with your wealth but whether the wealth was ever wholly yours to be generous with. It said that there is a portion of what you hold that has another person's name on it already, written by God, and that you are not its owner but its trustee, and that the day you forget this you have begun, quietly and respectably, to steal.

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*The Fathers did not praise the rich  
man for giving to the poor. They  
accused him of theft when he did not,  
because they believed the surplus was  
never his. We turned their justice into  
our charity, and congratulated  
ourselves for returning a fraction of  
what we had taken.*

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**THIS IS THE DOCTRINE** we lost, and losing it changed everything downstream. Once giving to the poor became optional generosity rather than required justice, the whole biblical weight of the thing evaporated. A man could be a faithful Christian, respected, devout, doctrinally sound, and

give almost nothing, and no one would think to question his standing, because charity is praiseworthy when present and merely unfortunate when absent. The Fathers would not have recognized that man as a faithful Christian at all. They would have looked at his full barns and his empty almsgiving and concluded that whatever he believed about the Trinity, he had not yet understood the gospel, because the gospel had reorganized everything about how he held his goods, and his goods showed that it had not. The recovery this book is after begins exactly here, with the recovery of a single word. Not charity. Justice. And to see why the Fathers were so sure of it, we have to go back before them, to the God they had learned it from.

## CHAPTER TWO

# The God Who Heard the Cry

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**THE FATHERS DID NOT** invent the church's concern for the poor. They inherited it, from a story so old it stands at the very foundation of the people of God, a story that tells you, before anything else, whose side God takes when the powerful crush the weak. Israel did not begin as a nation or an idea. It began as a cry. A mass of slaves under an empire that worked them to death making bricks, and a God who, the text says with deliberate repetition, heard them. I have surely seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt, God tells Moses from the burning bush, and have heard their cry because of their taskmasters. I know their sufferings, and I have come down to deliver them.

Sit with how strange and decisive that is as the opening move of the whole biblical drama. The God of the Bible introduces himself to history not as the patron of the strong, the way the gods of the empires always were, but as the one who hears the groan of slaves and comes down to break their chains. The founding act of the Old Testament is a liberation

of the oppressed, an act of justice on behalf of people who had no power and, the text is careful to note, no particular righteousness either. God did not free Israel because Israel was good. He freed Israel because Israel was crushed, and because he is the kind of God who hears that kind of cry. The exodus is not a footnote to the faith. It is the faith's first self-portrait of God, and the portrait shows him with his ear bent toward the bottom of the world.

And everything that follows is built on it. When God gives Israel its law, the law keeps circling back to one refrain, stated as the reason behind command after command. You shall not wrong a sojourner or oppress him, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt. You shall not mistreat any widow or fatherless child. When you reap your harvest you shall leave the corners of the field and the gleanings for the poor and the sojourner. Over and over the motive clause is the same. Because you were slaves, and you remember what it was to be at the bottom, and the God who heard your cry will hear theirs. The whole ethical architecture of Israel was designed to build a society that could never become the Egypt it had escaped, a society with the memory of slavery written into its statutes precisely so that it would never again let anyone be ground to powder.

This is what the Fathers had soaked in, and it is what we have lost the moment we treat care for the poor as an optional add-on to a faith that is really about something else. It was never an add-on. It is woven into the identity of God from the first chapter of the story, and a people who claim that God while ignoring the cry he is famous for hearing have not understood the God they claim. The danger the law was guarding against is the oldest danger there is, the danger that the liberated become the oppressors, that the people who

were slaves build, the moment they have a little power, their own pyramids on someone else's back. And the safeguard was memory. Remember you were slaves. Remember the cry. Keep your ear bent where God bends his.

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*God introduced himself to history as  
the one who heard the cry of slaves and  
came down. A people who worship that  
God and cannot hear that cry have  
mistaken him for one of the gods of  
Egypt, who always sided with the  
strong.*

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**SO BEFORE THERE IS** a single word from Basil or Ambrose, there is the burning bush, and the God who comes down, and a law shot through with the memory of the lash, all of it insisting that how you treat the powerless is not a sub-category of your religion but the test of whether your religion has any contact with the real God at all. The prophets will spend centuries hammering this, the Fathers will spend their lives applying it, and Jesus will stand in a synagogue and announce that his entire ministry is its fulfillment. But it starts here, with a cry that reached heaven, and a God who could not leave it unanswered. And the law that cry produced went looking, first of all, for the people with no one else to hear them.

## CHAPTER THREE

# The Widow and the Orphan

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**IF YOU WANT TO** know what a society actually worships, do not listen to what it says about itself. Look at what it does with the people who can do nothing for it in return. The Scriptures knew this, and so they reach again and again for a particular pair, almost a refrain, the widow and the orphan, and often a third joined to them, the stranger. In the ancient world these were not random examples of hardship. They were the precise list of people who had no man to stand for them, no husband, no father, no clan in the land, and therefore no standing in the court, no voice in the gate, no protector when the powerful came to take what little they had. They were the definition of vulnerable, the ones the system was built to overlook.

And God, with a kind of holy stubbornness, appoints himself their advocate. Father of the fatherless and protector of widows is God in his holy habitation, sings the psalm, and the image is staggering when you slow down on it. The God who flung the stars takes as one of his own titles the defender

of the orphan, the one who personally stands in for the child no one else will protect. The law made it concrete and enforceable. You shall not mistreat any widow or fatherless child. If you do mistreat them, and they cry out to me, I will surely hear their cry, God says, in language deliberately echoing the cry of the slaves in Egypt, and my wrath will burn. The most vulnerable people in Israel were given the most powerful possible advocate, and the warning to anyone who would exploit them was that they were exploiting people God had personally taken under his own protection.

This becomes, throughout the Scriptures, the test, the diagnostic God runs on a people to see whether their religion is real. The prophets do not measure Israel's faithfulness by the size of its temple or the fervor of its festivals. They measure it at the margins, by what is happening to the widow and the orphan and the stranger, because that is where a society's true god always reveals itself. And when the New Testament wants to define pure religion, stripped to its essence, it reaches for the same ancient pair without hesitation. Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this, writes James, to visit orphans and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained from the world. Not to attend orphans and widows in addition to real religion. That, along with personal holiness, simply is pure religion, named as its definition.

We have to let that land against our own instinctive measures of a faithful church. We tend to assess a church by its doctrine, its attendance, its energy, the quality of its teaching, and none of those are nothing. But the Scriptures keep insisting on a measure we rarely use, which is what is happening, through this people, to the ones who cannot pay them back. A church can be doctrinally immaculate and

biblically illiterate at the same time, orthodox in every article of the creed and a stranger to the religion James called pure, if it has learned to recite the faith while overlooking the widow at its own door. The test God runs is not first what do you believe. It is who is being cared for because you are here, and specifically, are the people with no advocate finding one in you.

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*God took as one of his own names the  
defender of the orphan and the widow.  
The surest measure of whether a people  
knows him is not the soundness of its  
doctrine but the safety of its most  
defenseless, because that is where he  
has chosen to stand.*

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**SO THE RECOVERY OF** the church's nerve about the poor is not, at bottom, about economics or politics at all. It is about whether we will measure ourselves the way God measures us, at the margin rather than the center, by the widow rather than the budget, by the orphan rather than the attendance. It is about whether we still believe what Israel was told and the Fathers never forgot, that the living God has stationed himself among the defenseless, and that to walk past them is to walk past him. And there was one group the law pressed onto Israel's conscience with special force, a group the modern church finds it hardest of all to receive as a sacred trust,

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because it has become the most political word we have. The stranger.

## CHAPTER FOUR

# The Stranger in the Land

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**OF ALL THE COMMANDS** the law presses on Israel, none is repeated more often than the command concerning the stranger, the foreigner, the immigrant, the one the Hebrew calls the ger, the person living in a land not their own. By the count of the rabbis the instruction to love and protect the stranger appears more times in the law than almost any other single command, and the reason given is always the same, the reason that is the beating heart of the whole Torah. You shall love the sojourner, therefore, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt. You know the heart of a stranger. You were one. You remember what it was to be the foreigner with no rights, no land, no protection, at the mercy of people who owed you nothing. Therefore, God says, you of all people will not do to the stranger what was done to you.

The God of Israel describes himself, in the same breath as the orphan and the widow, as the one who loves the sojourner, giving him food and clothing, and he commands his people to extend the same. The stranger was written into

the safety net of the law. He shared in the gleanings of the field. He rested on the sabbath. He was to receive equal justice in the courts, one law for the native and the foreigner alike. He was not to be a second class of person, tolerated and exploited, but protected with the same fierce care as the most vulnerable of Israel's own. And the early church carried this forward as one of its defining marks, the love of strangers, philoxenia, hospitality not as a dinner party among friends but as the dangerous, costly opening of your home and your bread to the foreigner and the traveler and the one with nowhere to go. The church grew, in part, because it was a place where the stranger was taken in.

Now I have to be careful here, more careful than anywhere else in this book, because this is the place where the ancient teaching collides most violently with our modern politics, and where the temptation to baptize a partisan position is strongest on every side. The Scriptures are not a policy paper. They do not hand us a modern immigration system, and the genuine complexities of borders and law and the common good are real, and a serious Christian can hold a range of prudential views about how a nation should order these things. I am not telling you how to vote. But underneath and before every prudential question there is a posture, a disposition of the heart toward the stranger, that Scripture does not leave to our discretion, and it is this. The foreigner is not first a threat to be managed. He is first a person God loves and commands you to love, made in the image you share, and the memory you are to keep is not of your security but of your own time as a stranger.

And the hard truth is that the American church has very largely let its politics form its posture here rather than the other way around, has absorbed from the surrounding

culture a reflex of fear and suspicion toward the stranger and then gone looking for verses to justify it, when the overwhelming weight of the law and the prophets and the practice of the early church runs the other direction. This is exactly the inversion this whole book is about, the moment we let the tribe tell us how to read the Scripture instead of letting the Scripture judge the tribe. You may land, after wrestling honestly with the complexities, on a hundred different policies. You may not land on a hardened heart, because the command about the stranger is not finally a position to be debated. It is a memory to be kept. You were strangers in the land of Egypt, and you know the heart of a stranger, and the God who took you in when you were one is watching what you do with the next one who comes to your gate.

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*The command about the stranger is not a policy. It is a memory. You were the foreigner once, with no rights and no protector, and the God who loved you then is watching how you treat the one standing now where you used to stand.*

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**THIS IS AMONG THE** costliest recoveries the modern church could make, because it cuts directly against a fear that the culture has worked hard to cultivate, and to recover the

biblical posture toward the stranger will sound, to many in the church, like a betrayal of the tribe. It is not. It is a return to the law God gave and the church once kept. And it connects to something even larger and stranger in the law, an entire economic vision built on the same memory of Egypt, a vision so radical that Israel could never bring itself to obey it, and that the church has scarcely dared to read. The year when all debts died.

## CHAPTER FIVE

# The Year of Release

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**BURIED IN THE BOOK** of Leviticus, in a chapter we never preach, is one of the most astonishing pieces of legislation in the history of the world, and the fact that most Christians have never heard of it tells you everything about how thoroughly we have learned to read past the parts of the Bible that threaten us. It is called the Jubilee. Every fifty years, God commanded, a trumpet was to sound across the land, and when it sounded, everything reset. All debts were cancelled. All Israelites who had sold themselves into servitude to pay those debts went free. And all land that had been sold off returned to the families who had originally been given it. Every half century, the economy was returned to something near its starting line, and no debt, no servitude, no concentration of land was allowed to become permanent.

Understand what this vision assumes and what it forbids. It assumes that the land is not finally ours but God's, held in trust, as he says plainly in the chapter, the land shall not be sold in perpetuity, for the land is mine, for you are strangers and sojourners with me. We are tenants, not owners, even of the ground beneath us. And it forbids the one thing every human economy drifts toward and ours has perfected, the

permanent division of people into a class that accumulates without limit and a class that sinks without rescue. The Jubilee built into the very calendar of Israel a mechanism of release, a regular, structural undoing of the inequalities that pile up over time, so that no family could be locked into poverty forever and no family could amass everything forever. There was a ceiling, and there was a floor, and every fifty years the trumpet reminded everyone that the whole arrangement belonged to God.

Israel, as far as we can tell, never once fully kept it. The Jubilee stands in the law as a vision more than a practice, an indictment Israel carried in its own scriptures of the gap between what God commanded and what the powerful would allow. And the prophets thundered into that gap, raging against those who add house to house and field to field until there is no room for anyone else, against the foreclosing and the debt-slavery and the endless accumulation that the Jubilee was meant to prevent. But what should stop every Christian who has skipped Leviticus 25 is where it surfaces next. When Jesus stood up in the synagogue at Nazareth to announce what his entire ministry would be, the text he chose, the words he read and then said were fulfilled in him, were the words of Isaiah proclaiming the year of the Lord's favor, which is the Jubilee. Good news to the poor. Liberty to the captives. Release for the oppressed. Jesus opened his public ministry by declaring a Jubilee, and we have managed, remarkably, to make his gospel about almost anything except the thing he said it was about in his first sermon.

I am not naive enough to think the answer is to legislate Leviticus 25 into the American tax code, and that is not the point. The point is that God's imagination for an economy has shape, and the shape has limits on accumulation and

mechanisms of release and a bone-deep conviction that permanent poverty is not natural or acceptable but an offense to be regularly undone, and that we have built an economy with no trumpet, no reset, no ceiling and no floor, and then baptized its outcomes as simply the way things are. The Jubilee will not tell you which policies to support. But it will refuse to let you believe that the way wealth currently concentrates and poverty currently hardens is a neutral fact of nature rather than a human arrangement that God, in his own law, insisted should never be allowed to become permanent. We read past Jubilee because it frightens us, and we are right to be frightened, because it means our economy is not beyond the reach of God's judgment, and neither is our place in it.

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*God built a trumpet into Israel's  
calendar that cancelled every debt and  
freed every captive every fifty years,  
because he refuses to accept permanent  
poverty as natural. We built an  
economy with no trumpet, and called  
the result the way of the world.*

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**THE JUBILEE IS THE** law's boldest statement of a conviction that runs through the whole of Scripture, that God claims authority over money and land and debt, that there is no realm of life sealed off from his lordship and labeled merely

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economic, merely private, merely the market. And it was precisely this conviction, that worship and wealth and justice are not separate compartments but one seamless thing before God, that the prophets pressed on Israel with the most terrifying words in the entire Bible, words that should make every church in America tremble before its next worship service. The words where God says he hates the songs we sing him.

## CHAPTER SIX

# Let Justice Roll

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**THERE IS A MOMENT** in the prophet Amos so severe that I am not sure most of us have ever let ourselves hear it, because if we did it would ruin our composure in church. God is speaking, through Amos, to a people whose worship was thriving. The festivals were full. The offerings were generous. The music was good and the assemblies were crowded and the religion, by every external measure, was booming. And into that flourishing religious scene God says this. I hate, I despise your feasts, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. Take away from me the noise of your songs. To the melody of your harps I will not listen. The God of Israel tells his own worshippers that their worship nauseates him, that he cannot stand the sound of their singing, that he wants the whole production to stop.

Why. The next line tells you, and it is the hinge of the entire prophetic message. But let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream. The worship disgusted God because the people offering it were trampling the poor the rest of the week, selling the needy for a pair of sandals, taking bribes and pushing aside the destitute in the gate, and then arriving on the holy day to sing

their songs as though the two had nothing to do with each other. And God, through Amos, refuses the split. He will not accept worship from hands that have robbed the poor. He does not want their music while they ignore the cry he has always heard. The songs are not a way around the justice. Where the justice is absent, the songs are an offense, the noise of people performing a relationship with a God whose deepest concerns they trample every day they are not in the building.

This is the prophetic word in its purest and most unbearable form, and it is everywhere once you see it. Isaiah opens with God sick of their sacrifices and their incense and their festivals, telling them their hands are full of blood, and then the remedy, cease to do evil, learn to do good, seek justice, correct oppression, bring justice to the fatherless, plead the widow's cause. Micah strips the whole of religion down to a single sentence that has never been improved upon. He has told you, O man, what is good, and what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God. Not to perform justice occasionally as one item among many, but to do justice as the very substance of what God requires, alongside mercy and humility, the three together making the whole of true religion. The prophets are relentless and they are unanimous. God will not be worshipped by people who oppress the poor, and the more impressive their worship, the more it offends him.

I have to turn this on us, on me, because the prophets never let the indictment stay safely in the past. We have built, in the American church, a worship culture of extraordinary production and emotional power, the lights and the music and the carefully crafted experience, and I have helped build it and I have been moved by it and I am not against it. But

Amos forces a question I would rather not ask. Is it possible that God hates some of our worship? Is it possible that he is sick of the noise of our songs, not because the songs are bad but because the people singing them, myself among them, have learned to feel close to God on Sunday while remaining comfortably indifferent to the poor at the gate on Monday, and that the very excellence of the worship makes the indifference more offensive rather than less? The prophets would not have hesitated over that question. They would have said yes, and they would have told us to turn off the harps until justice ran in the streets.

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*God told his own worshippers that he  
hated their songs. Not because the  
music was poor, but because their  
hands were full of the poor they had  
robbed, and he will not be serenaded  
by people who trample the ones he  
came down to hear.*

---

**THIS IS THE CONVICTION** the Fathers inherited and the reason they preached about wealth with such ferocity, because they believed, as the prophets did, that you cannot separate the altar from the gate, that what you do with your money is part of your worship and not a secular matter outside it, and that a Christianity which is fervent on Sunday and indifferent to the poor the rest of the week is not a

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slightly incomplete Christianity but one the prophets would have called an abomination. And they did not only preach it. That is what makes the early church so dangerous to our excuses. They actually did the thing, on a scale that embarrassed an empire, and to that astonishing history we now turn.

## CHAPTER SEVEN

# The Church That Shamed the Empire

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**FOR ITS FIRST THREE** centuries the church had no power to change a single law of Rome, no senators, no emperors, no hold on the machinery of the state, and so it did the only thing it could do, which turned out to be the most powerful thing of all. It simply cared for the poor, its own and everyone else's, with a reckless, organized, relentless generosity the ancient world had never seen, and in doing so it became an argument that Rome could not answer. The pagan world had its occasional benefactors, its rich men who funded a games or a temple for the glory of their own name. It had nothing like this, a whole community organized from top to bottom around the care of the destitute, the widow, the orphan, the sick, the imprisoned, the stranger, as a matter of ordinary faith.

When the great plagues swept the empire, the one in the 160s and the terrible one in the 250s that bears Cyprian's name, and the cities filled with the dying, the pagan response was the rational one. You fled. You left the sick by the road,

even your own, because to stay was to risk death. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at staggering cost to themselves, burying the dead the city would not touch, and the watching world could not comprehend it and could not forget it. By the fourth century Basil did not merely preach about the poor, he built for them, raising outside Caesarea a vast complex of hospitals and hostels and homes for the destitute and the leprous, a whole new city of mercy that people called the Basiliad, a structural, permanent, institutional answer to human need that the empire had never imagined was the business of religion at all.

And we have, from the other side, a piece of testimony so devastating that no Christian apologist could have invented it. In the fourth century the emperor Julian, called the Apostate because he tried to drag the empire back to paganism after Constantine, found that he could not compete with the Christians he despised, and he knew exactly why. In a letter to a pagan priest, trying to organize a pagan charity to match the Christian one, he wrote in frustration that it was disgraceful that the impious Galileans, his sneering name for the Christians, supported not only their own poor but ours as well, while our poor lack our care. The pagan emperor, the enemy of the church, bore witness that the Christians were out-loving his entire civilization at its most vulnerable point, and that this, more than any argument, was winning them the world. They conquered Rome from underneath, not with the sword and not with the vote, but with bread.

Set that beside the modern American church and feel the distance we have traveled. We have wealth and influence and political access the early church could not have dreamed of, and we have largely spent it trying to capture the levers of the

state, to win the culture by winning power, while the actual, daily, costly care of the poor has become for many congregations a line item, a committee, a program politely funded and safely outsourced, rather than the beating heart of the community's life. The early church had no power and changed everything by emptying itself for the poor. We have power and change little, because we have kept our barns full and our hands clean and let the state and the nonprofit handle what the Fathers considered the first business of the people of God. They did not lobby Rome to feed the hungry. They fed the hungry until Rome was ashamed. That is the strategy we abandoned, and it is the one that actually worked.

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*The early church had no power, so it simply fed the poor, its own and the pagans' too, until a hostile emperor admitted it was beating his entire civilization with bread. We have power, and full barns, and we wonder why our witness is so weak.*

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**THE HISTORY IS NOT** nostalgia and it is not a museum piece. It is a rebuke and a summons, a reminder that there was a time when the church's care for the poor was so total and so visible that it converted an empire, and that the thing which made that possible was not a strategy or a budget but a conviction, the conviction the prophets thundered and the

## WHAT BELONGS TO THE POOR

Fathers preached and the martyrs lived, that the poor have a claim on us that comes from God himself. And that conviction has a face, and a name, and a warning attached to it that the early church took with deadly seriousness and we have learned to skip, the scene Jesus said would decide the judgment of the nations, where the King turns out to have been in disguise the whole time.

## CHAPTER EIGHT

# The Least of These

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**JESUS TOLD ONE STORY** about the final judgment, one scene of the last day laid out in detail, and it is not about what we expected and it is not about what we argue over and most of us have quietly filed it away because it frightens us. In Matthew 25 the Son of Man comes in glory and gathers all the nations before him and separates them as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and the basis of the separation is a single thing. Not their theology. Not their religious experience. Not the correctness of their beliefs. What they did, or failed to do, for the hungry, the thirsty, the stranger, the naked, the sick, and the prisoner. I was hungry and you gave me food, the King says to those he welcomes, I was a stranger and you welcomed me, I was naked and you clothed me. And to the others, the same list, in the negative, I was hungry and you gave me no food, and on that, the text says, hangs their eternity.

What makes the scene unbearable is the line that explains it, the line that has haunted the church since it was first spoken. As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me. The King identifies himself, personally and completely, with the destitute. The hungry man was him. The

stranger was him. The prisoner was him. To feed the poor was to feed Christ, and to walk past the poor was to walk past Christ, and the terrifying detail is that neither group knew it. Lord, when did we see you hungry, both the sheep and the goats ask, because neither recognized him in the face of the poor. The righteous fed him without knowing it was him. The condemned ignored him without knowing it was him. And the not-knowing did not change the verdict, because Christ had hidden himself exactly where he always said he would be found, at the bottom, in the least, among the people the world overlooks.

The goats are not condemned for cruelty. Read it again, because this is the part that should ruin our complacency. They are not sent away for beating the poor or robbing the widow or any active wickedness. They are condemned for not noticing. For passing by. For a life lived comfortably alongside suffering they never quite registered, need they never quite saw, a Christ at the gate they stepped over on the way to somewhere more important. It is the sin of the respectable, the sin of the comfortable, the sin most available to people like me and most of the people who will read this book, the sin not of malice but of inattention, of having so arranged our lives that the poor became invisible and Christ along with them. And against that sin Jesus sets the whole weight of the last judgment, which means the thing we have treated as optional, as charity, as politics, as someone else's department, is the thing he said he would judge the nations by.

So let me bring the whole book to its point, and refuse, at the end, to let it be captured by either tribe, because that capture is most of how we have escaped it. The political left has taken the Bible's passion for the poor and too often

emptied it of God, made it a program of the state and a posture of grievance, kept the justice and lost the Lord. The political right has taken the Bible's call to personal holiness and too often emptied it of the poor, made the gospel a private transaction about my soul and my morality, kept the Lord and lost the justice. And the scene in Matthew 25 stands over both of them and will be captured by neither, because it insists on the whole thing at once, the King and the least of these together, personal devotion to Christ that proves itself precisely in the bread it puts in the hands of the poor, justice and worship revealed at last to have been the same thing all along. The early church knew this. The Fathers preached it. We have spent a century arguing about which half to keep.

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*Christ said he would judge the nations  
by what they did for the hungry and  
the stranger and the prisoner, because  
he had hidden himself among them.  
And the goats were not damned for  
cruelty. They were damned for not  
noticing. That is the sin most available  
to the comfortable, and it is the one he  
warned would cost us everything.*

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**WHAT BELONGS TO THE** poor, in the end, is not only the bread in our cupboards, though Basil was right that it is that.

## WHAT BELONGS TO THE POOR

What belongs to the poor is Christ himself, who took their place and wears their faces and waits at our gates in their need, and who has told us with perfect clarity that what we do with them is what we are doing with him. The ancient church organized its entire life around this and turned the world upside down. We have organized our life around almost everything else and wondered why our gospel has gone quiet. The trumpet of the Jubilee is not going to sound from the government, and the songs God hates are not going to please him no matter how well we produce them, and the King is not going to be fooled on the last day by our doctrine if our hands were closed. There is a man at your gate. There has been the whole time. The only question the gospel finally asks of your wealth is the one the King will ask on the last day, and it is not how much did you keep, and it is not how generous did you feel. It is far simpler, and far more terrible, and far more full of grace than that. Did you see me.